

**Time:** 6 minutes**Outcome:** Calculate trade and capital balances and connect NX, NCO, saving, and investment.**Difficulty:**

Intermediate

International Transactions and Open-Economy Identities



THE CORE IDEA

Net exports are exports minus imports: $NX = X - M$. Positive NX is a trade surplus; negative NX is a trade deficit. Net capital outflow (NCO) is domestic purchases of foreign assets minus foreign purchases of domestic assets. In simplified accounting without net income or transfers from abroad, $NX = NCO$. National saving finances domestic investment and NCO, so $S = I + NCO = I + NX$.



HOW TO RECOGNIZE IT

- Exports add to NX; imports subtract from NX.
- A domestic resident buying a foreign asset raises capital outflow and NCO.
- A foreign resident buying a domestic asset lowers NCO and is a capital inflow.
- If S exceeds I, the difference is positive NCO and positive NX.



WATCH OUT

A trade deficit is consistent with negative net capital outflow: foreign purchases of domestic assets exceed domestic purchases of foreign assets. Use the same period and accounting assumptions for both measures.



WORKED EXAMPLE: MATCHING THE TWO SIDES

Trade and asset transactions (billions of dollars)

	Positive flow	Negative flow	Net
Goods: NX	Exports 300	Imports 360	-60
Assets: NCO	Residents buy foreign 90	Foreigners buy domestic 150	-60

Exports are \$300 billion and imports are \$360 billion, so $NX = -\$60$ billion. Residents buy \$90 billion of foreign assets while foreigners buy \$150 billion of domestic assets, so $NCO = \$90 - \$150 = -\$60$ billion. If investment is \$240 billion, saving is $I + NCO = \$180$ billion.



CHECK YOURSELF

National saving is \$250 billion and investment is \$210 billion. What are NCO and NX?

**READY?**

Return to the game and master this concept.